

portable device that could make calls, access the internet, message friends or download apps, they would just buy a smartphone.

After an initial flurry, it seems like the smartwatch market is now settling down. Manufacturers have settled on the idea that the smartwatch is better off as an accessory to the smartphone rather than a standalone device. However, smartwatches are starting to get a smidge of tech that makes them a little less dependent on smartphones. The most notable was the e-SIM that allowed these devices



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to take phone calls and have access to the internet without the need to stay tethered to the smartphone. Further, as the e-SIM had the same number as the phone, it was more like an extension of the smartphone instead of a standalone device.

Health and fitness has also become a key aspect that manufacturers have been leaning heavy into. As it turns out, a watch is possibly the most non-invasive way to keep track of your well being. Unlike your phone which you may keep on your desk most of the time, you continually wear a watch. This means more accurate and detailed metrics as data points are gathered all through the day.

So have we reached the peak of smartwatch technology? Not by a longshot. These devices have just about started to hit their stride and with the way things are going, we are looking at something big. So what can we expect in the next 20 years? Let's peer into the crystal ball...

WHAT DOES THE FUTURE HOLD?

Considering how young the modern smartwatch really is, manufacturers are still experimenting with new

features. Some will work, most won't. That's just how things are. Which is why the next 20 odd years are so exciting. Most probably the next five to ten years will see the most innovation and things will slowly start to settle after that. So what is in store?

Instead of being just another accessory to smartphones, smartwatches will become an extension of our primary devices. We're already seeing glimpses of these with e-SIM wearables that don't need to be within Bluetooth range in order to function. It will reduce our dependence on smartphones, not necessarily usurping them as the primary device. Considering how most current wearable tech is closely connected to smartphone technology, the next big innovations in smartwatch tech would most likely mirror the big innovations in smartphone technology. So expect things like 5G, AI and so much more coming to a smartwatch near you!

However, the next big step in terms of hardware will mostly be in battery life. With so much focus on graphene batteries, the next 20 years may see the graphene battery overtake the lithium-ion battery as the go-to battery. Graphene batteries are tipped to offer higher capacity, longer lifespan and faster charging. But if we really were to dream, maybe scientists will take a cue from traditional automatic watches and develop a smartwatch that uses the natural movements of the hand to charge the device, thereby never needing a charge. As a bonus, there will be one less device to charge in your life. Huzzah!

As an extension of your smartphone, smartwatches will play a key role in the Internet of Things (IoT) ecosystem. Simply put, you wouldn't need to carry your smartphone in your pocket all the time. Devices would recognise the wearable and possibly use it to keep better track of you. For example, only certain lights could turn on based on where you were in the room. Speakers could tune their acoustics based on where exactly you were sitting.

Since a wearable device is literally connected to your hands, it would

only be a matter of time before gestures are added to the mix. A quick wave of your hand could turn off lights, or turn on devices. Is your car parked in a tight spot? Simply gesture your car to drive itself to where you are. When the inevitable kaiju apocalypse does happen, a wearable could be used to track the intricate battle dance needed to summon your personal giant robot. Pretty obvious really...

To keep things real for a moment, wearables will be used for battle. But instead of fighting giant robots, it will be used to battle diseases and other ailments. The current smartwatches can already track things like SpO₂ levels, heart rate and more. In the future, other sensors might be added to track even more key metrics. This information could then be used by doctors to gauge a patient's health. This would be a boon, especially for at risk patients and might even end up saving lives.

Wearables with AI could revolutionise fitness. The AI could read your metrics and then suggest workout routines and diets based on



Xiaomi Mi Band 2

Credit: Nahid Rajbd

that information. It would even help with physio and recovery as it could encourage people to push themselves every so slightly forward while giving physios an update on their recovery.

The watch was probably one of the earliest portable tech mankind had. While many technologies have since come and gone, the watch is still with us. Sure, it may not be the same thing it was a century ago, but that's the reason for its success. The device is flexible enough to adapt to almost any need and it is this flexibility that will ensure it will still be relevant in some shape of form, 20 years down the line. 